short, is now ripe for the SDF to strike.

Chamling, now 73, is back on the scene too, announcing that he'd be the CM candidate for the 2024 polls. With most of his top leaders gone, he's rebuilding the SDF, depending on young blood. "We have lost a lot of deadwood (defectors). The focus is on educated youth," Rai adds. Persons between 18 and 45 comprise over 50 per cent of Sikkim's population; likewise, three out of four SDF leaders are relatively young. Karna Bhutiya, 39, is head of the farmer front, 31-year-old Arun Subba heads the labour front, Rickzing Norbu Bhutiya, 30, heads the student front. Young leaders, Chamling hopes, can tap into the youth's aspirations. The party plans to tackle the blights hounding Sikkim—drug abuse,

WITH A LOT OF THE 'DEADWOOD' GONE, EX-CM CHAMLING'S NEW-LOOK PARTY IS DEPENDING ON YOUNG LEADERS

child abuse, mental health issues.

The SDF is also weighing in on national issues with a bearing on the state's future. Spokesperson M.K. Subba feels India's border security will be at stake with the Citizenship (Amendment) Act. "There will be an influx of people from Bangladesh, Pakistan and Afghanistan. The Restricted Area Permit applicable for foreign nationals will not hold once CAA comes into force. We'll sensitise the youth about the dangers ahead," he adds. The party is opening new offices in 30 districts. Highlighting achievements of past Chamling governments as well as showcasing a new-look party are high on the agenda. The critical role an opposition could have played is missing, says Subba, with CM Golay allying with the BJP in 2020. Only the SDF can reclaim that democratic space now, he says. They have over a year to drive home their message. ■



LAW CATCHES UP Mukhtar Ansari being produced in court

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UTTAR PRADESH

YOGI, THE PROSECUTOR

By Prashant Srivastava

Yogi Adityanath's first term as Uttar Pradesh chief minister got huge attention for its 'bulldozer action' against the properties of mafia dons. In his second term, Yogi has taken it a step further with 'Mission Punishment'. So now, alongside the bulldozers, the government is focusing on legal prosecution and securing convictions of these bahubalis.

The UP administration says it has identified 62 mafia gangs who they will be going after. Big names in the list include gangster-turned-netas Mukhtar Ansari, Atiq Ahmad and Vijay Mishra. Other prominent names from Purvanchal include Dhruv Kumar a.k.a. Kuntu Singh, Mohammad Ashra and Khan Mubarak; and Yogesh Bhadoda, Amit Kasana, Billu Dujana and Aakash Jat from western UP. An official source says the CM is personally reviewing the progress in the prosecution cases against these criminals.

The new zeal is already showing results. Recently, Mukhtar Ansari, a five-time MLA from Mau, was convicted in two cases within a week, one of them dating back to 1999. Prashant Kumar, ADGP, law and order, says, "The 62 gangs on our list are being monitored by UP Police HQ. We have attached properties worth Rs 2,200 crore of these dons in the past six months."

ADGP (prosecution) Ashutosh Pandey says that the use of technology and e-prosecution (digital prosecution) has helped smoothen out the whole process. "Uttar Pradesh is the top state in terms of both entry and disposal of cases through the Centre's e-Prosecution portal," he says. Some 9.12 million cases had been resolved this way till August end, he claims. The portal, through the Inter-operable Criminal Justice System (ICJS), enables sharing of data among the courts, police, jails and forensic science laboratories.

The opposition, though, isn't too impressed. SP spokesperson Ashutosh Verma asks, "The Yogi regime selectively targets 3-4 mafia dons and keeps boasting about the action taken against them. Why don't they talk about convicting Union minister Ajay Mishra Teni's son in the Lakhimpur incident? Or about convictions in the Hathras and Unnao rape cases?" It seems the UP home department has a few wrinkles to iron out. ■